

Bhavish Aggarwal, 37, the aggressive, straight-talking Co-founder & CEO of Ola, is currently a man on a mission: to make India a global leader in electric mobility. Two of his companies—ride-hailing venture Ola and electric mobility company Ola Electric—are in the midst of rapid scaling up. But EV two-wheeler market leader Ola Electric, with a range of scooters, an upcoming motorcycle range and plans for a car launch by next year, is where the bulk of the action is. In a freewheeling conversation with *Business Today's* Sourav Majumdar, Aggarwal talks about his vision for the EV sector, his plans for the ride-hailing venture, and more. Edited excerpts:

Q: Bhavish, to start off, give us an overview of where Ola stands at this point.

A: I am very optimistic about India in general and about technology and, obviously, about our company. Let me share a bit with you about how Ola is growing. [The] Ola group is now three companies. Ola, which is my consumer company, where ride-hailing was my main business, is profitable and is growing well. You will see us do a few very interesting AI applications in Ola. And I will talk about that more as the conversation progresses. We are the No. 1 firm by ride-hailing market share.

Q: What is the current market share?

A: There are different numbers, but 60 per cent is more or less the media- and third-party number.

Q: What is the status of your IPO plans for Ola?

A: We tried to list it last year, but we didn't do it. We will do it soon. Then, Ola Electric is now India's No. 1 EV company by revenue—even bigger than the four-wheeler EV companies by revenue—and last year we scaled up manufacturing, our front-end [and] back-end. In January last year, we started selling. Last year was a very action-filled year for us at Ola Electric. It's a massive undertaking and it was very exciting. I have been

very optimistic... not just optimistic but very aggressive about India's need to lead the world in electrification.

Q: That has been the broad vision for Ola Electric, right?

A: EV, sustainability, climate change, etc., are all important global themes now and to truly take sustainability and the EV mission to humanity scale, India needs to be electrified, because whatever companies like Tesla, etc. are doing in the West are for the western audience. The majority of the world doesn't use those products. And India is a great microcosm of the rest of the world.

Q: The government is also giving a big push to electrification...

A: Yes, the government is very supportive. It is an opportunity for an Indian company to build products that Indians want and scale them beyond India—also because there are many large geographies that will use these kinds of products. That's been our vision from Day One in Ola Electric, so we have been focussed on building three pillars of our strategy. It is building a spectrum of two-wheelers, building cars, and the third pillar has been vertically integrating into cell technology. All three pillars of our strategy are very fast in motion. In two-wheelers we are the leaders in India—we also teased our motorcycles a few weeks ago. Motorcycles will be launched this year and next year we will launch a bunch of motorcycles. Towards the end of the next year, our car will also be launched.

Q: Talking about the range of products, you are now going to get into the mass market in scooters—the Activa segment. Then there are motorcycles, that is the Hero segment; and then premium motorcycles, that is, the Bajaj and Royal Enfield segment. You are already the leader in premium scooters, where you started. Would you not be better off consolidating there and establishing leadership by far rather than doing all these things at this juncture?

A: Great question. And this movement in the automotive industry is very different from any other new entrant coming in. This is a technology shift. In a technology shift, every technology has an 'S' curve, for maturity, adoption, and value creation. And technologies shake up industry structure. You have seen 4G, there are so many examples. The way the internet shook up [things]. In the Silicon Valley, Microsoft and Apple used to dominate,